BRIGHT FUTURES HANDOUT ▶ **PARENT**

6 MONTH VISIT

Here are some suggestions from Bright Futures experts that may be of value to your family.

HOW YOUR FAMILY IS DOING

- If you are worried about your living or food situation, talk with us. Community agencies and programs such as WIC and SNAP can also provide information and assistance.
- Don't smoke or use e-cigarettes. Keep your home and car smoke-free. Tobacco-free spaces keep children healthy.
- Don't use alcohol or drugs.
- Choose a mature, trained, and responsible babysitter or caregiver.
- Ask us questions about child care programs.
- Talk with us or call for help if you feel sad or very tired for more than a few days.
- Spend time with family and friends.

YOUR BABY'S DEVELOPMENT

- Place your baby so she is sitting up and can look around.
- Talk with your baby by copying the sounds she makes.
- Look at and read books together.
- Play games such as peekaboo, patty-cake, and so big.
- Don't have a TV on in the background or use a TV or other digital media to calm your baby.
- If your baby is fussy, give her safe toys to hold and put into her mouth. Make sure she is getting regular naps and playtimes.

FEEDING YOUR BABY

- Know that your baby's growth will slow down.
- Be proud of yourself if you are still breastfeeding. Continue as long as you and your baby want.
- Use an iron-fortified formula if you are formula feeding.
- Begin to feed your baby solid food when he is ready.
- Look for signs your baby is ready for solids. He will
  - Open his mouth for the spoon.
  - Sit with support.
  - Show good head and neck control.
  - Be interested in foods you eat.

Starting New Foods

- Introduce one new food at a time.
- Use foods with good sources of iron and zinc, such as
  - Iron- and zinc-fortified cereal
  - Pureed red meat, such as beef or lamb
- Introduce fruits and vegetables after your baby eats iron- and zinc-fortified cereal or pureed meat well.
- Offer solid food 2 to 3 times per day; let him decide how much to eat.
- Avoid raw honey or large chunks of food that could cause choking.
- Consider introducing all other foods, including eggs and peanut butter, because research shows they may actually prevent individual food allergies.
- To prevent choking, give your baby only very soft, small bites of finger foods.
- Wash fruits and vegetables before serving.
- Introduce your baby to a cup with water, breast milk, or formula.
- Avoid feeding your baby too much; follow baby's signs of fullness, such as
  - Leaning back
  - Turning away
- Don't force your baby to eat or finish foods.
  - It may take 10 to 15 times of offering your baby a type of food to try before he likes it.

Helpful Resources: Smoking Quit Line: 800-784-8669 | Poison Help Line: 800-222-1222
Information About Car Safety Seats: www.safercar.gov/parents | Toll-free Auto Safety Hotline: 888-327-4236

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6 MONTH VISIT—PARENT

HEALTHY TEETH

- Ask us about the need for fluoride.
- Clean gums and teeth (as soon as you see the first tooth) 2 times per day with a soft cloth or soft toothbrush and a small smear of fluoride toothpaste (no more than a grain of rice).
- Don't give your baby a bottle in the crib. Never prop the bottle.
- Don't use foods or juices that your baby sucks out of a pouch.
- Don't share spoons or clean the pacifier in your mouth.

SAFETY

- Use a rear-facing–only car safety seat in the back seat of all vehicles.
- Never put your baby in the front seat of a vehicle that has a passenger airbag.
- If your baby has reached the maximum height/weight allowed with your rear-facing–only car seat, you can use an approved convertible or 3-in-1 seat in the rear-facing position.
- Put your baby to sleep on her back.
- Choose crib with slats no more than 2⅜ inches apart.
  - Lower the crib mattress all the way.
- Don't use a drop-side crib.
- Don't put soft objects and loose bedding such as blankets, pillows, bumper pads, and toys in the crib.
- If you choose to use a mesh playpen, get one made after February 28, 2013.
- Do a home safety check (stair gates, barriers around space heaters, and covered electrical outlets).
- Don't leave your baby alone in the tub, near water, or in high places such as changing tables, beds, and sofas.
- Keep poisons, medicines, and cleaning supplies locked and out of your baby's sight and reach.
- Put the Poison Help line number into all phones, including cell phones. Call us if you are worried your baby has swallowed something harmful.
- Keep your baby in a high chair or playpen while you are in the kitchen.
- Do not use a baby walker.
- Keep small objects, cords, and latex balloons away from your baby.
- Keep your baby out of the sun. When you do go out, put a hat on your baby and apply sunscreen with SPF of 15 or higher on her exposed skin.

WHAT TO EXPECT AT YOUR BABY'S 9 MONTH VISIT

We will talk about

- Caring for your baby, your family, and yourself
- Teaching and playing with your baby
- Disciplining your baby
- Introducing new foods and establishing a routine
- Keeping your baby safe at home and in the car

Consistent with *Bright Futures: Guidelines for Health Supervision of Infants, Children, and Adolescents,* 4th Edition

For more information, go to https://brightfutures.aap.org.

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